regularly visited by Byzantines, Persians, Yemenis, Omanis, and even Ethiopians. There were merchants from the Mecca region too; Muhammad would have personally known several merchants who had visited India. The Cheraman Juma mosque in Kerala claims to have been established in 629 AD. If true, this would not just make it India's oldest mosque but also the second oldest in the world! [1] While exact dates are difficult to prove, there is no doubt that the mosque is very old and was built in the very early years of Islam. It stands close to the site of ancient Muzaris. Old photographs show that the building was originally an adaptation of local temple architecture. Sadly, during renovations in 1984, the old structure was replaced with one sprouting domes and minarets in order to conform to a more 'conventional' view of Islamic architecture. It was an inexcusable act of vandalism. Now there is talk of recreating the old structure to attract tourists, but it is never quite the same thing.

With the creation of the Islamic empire, with its headquarters in Baghdad, the Arabs came to control a vast trading network. Arab merchants sailed the Mediterranean, criss-crossed the Sahara in camel caravans, traded for Chinese silks in the bazaars of Central Asia and made their way down the East African coast in search of slaves. This was the age of Sindbad the Sailor. Even if the tales of the *One Thousand and One Nights* are fictional, they retain the colourful spirit of the times.

The Iraqi port of Basra became the most important trading hub of the empire because of its proximity to the capital. Indian goods and merchants so dominated the trade that the Arabs spoke of Basra as 'belonging to al-Hind'. [2] The merchandise included perfumes, spices, ginger, textiles and medicinal substances. After the Arab conquest of Sindh, large numbers of slaves were also brought in from the province [3] . Interestingly, the most important Indian export of the period was the steel sword. The country was famous at that time for the quality of its metallurgy, and the swords used by the early Muslim armies were often of Indian origin. [4] This remained true even at the time of the Christian Crusades and the famous 'Damascus